MOSAICS AND TRANSPARENCIES

Warren Burt
Box Hill Institute

ABSTRACT

Mosaics and Transparencies (2017) is a multichannel live electro-acoustic improvisational algorithmic composition that consists of a number of diverse sound recordings mixed and performed live over a multi-channel loudspeaker system.

The sound recordings are each 1⁄2 hour long, and any portion can be played as part of the mix. They consist of algorithmic mixes of up to 61 samples arrayed in time so that each sample occurs only once or twice or three times during the 1⁄2 hour duration.

The samples consist of a number of kinds of sounding material, each featuring lots of silence as well as sound:

1) Electro-acoustic sounds recorded with contact mics attached to a wooden resonator on which acoustic objects are placed. (Homage to Pauline Oliveros's "Applebox" series of pieces).

2) Riffs in microtonal scales played by samples of non-Western musical instruments (the UVI World Suite) controlled by the algorithmic generators in Joel Kivela's "Dhalang MG" program (Markov Chains, Physical Models of gravity/bouncing systems)(an homage to Ervin Wilson).

3) Sounds generated by converting a series of several hundred drawings made by hand over a 10 year period into sound, using 2C Audio's "Kaleidoscope" program. The partials of each sound are tuned into a different microtonal scale.

4) Samples of long individual tones played by samples of Western orchestral instruments (Spitfire, Garritan, VSL) modified by a wide variety of sound modification programs.

5) Acoustic recordings of various environmental sounds treated in a musique concrete manner.

6) A collection of short gestures made with analogue and digital synthesizers. Most are tuned to a wide variety of microtonal scales.

There are several different recordings of each of these kinds of sound materials, each one featuring a unique set of sound samples. These sound-type recordings are then mixed into a 1⁄2 hour composite recording, which while thicker in texture, still has substantial amounts of silence in it.

This collection of recordings is then mixed live into a sound-routing system, featuring as many channels as are available.